

Worksheet 2: My Ladder of Challenges

For: Pratham S | Age 16 | OPD No. 260703010 | Clinician: Mr. Tejas Dangodra

Now that we know your triggers and the reactions you use, we build a 'ladder'. Each rung is a situation or thought that brings up distress. We rank them from easiest at the bottom to hardest at the top. In therapy we start low and climb slowly, only when you feel ready. You are always in control of the pace.

Two rules before we build this ladder: (1) Safety is checked first every session - we only climb when the suicidal-risk part is stable. (2) Any exposure to knives, cutters, or rope is done WITH me, supervised, with means kept secure. We never practise those alone at this stage.

How to rate distress (SUDS)

Score	What it feels like
0 - 20	Calm / only a little uneasy
30 - 50	Noticeable distress but manageable
60 - 80	Strong distress, hard to stay with it
90 - 100	The most distress I can imagine

Building my ladder

Write each challenge and give it a SUDS score from 0-100. Include both real-life situations (in-vivo) and facing the thought itself in imagination (imaginal). Some examples from your case are pre-filled - keep, change, or delete them so the ladder is truly yours.

#	Challenge (situation OR thought to face)	In-vivo / Imaginal	SUDS
	Read the word 'knife' written on paper	In-vivo	
	Watch a mild news clip mentioning harm	In-vivo	
	Say the intrusive thought out loud in the room with me	Imaginal	
	Sit alone in a room for a few minutes (means secured)	In-vivo	
	Listen to a short recorded script of the thought	Imaginal	
	Be in the kitchen while a cutter is on the counter (supervised)	In-vivo	
	Hold a spoon / then a blunt object near a family member (supervised)	In-vivo	
	Sit close to my father without checking or reassurance	In-vivo	
	Full imaginal script of the feared thought, read slowly	Imaginal	

Putting them in order (low to high)

Now copy the challenges into order, starting with the LOWEST SUDS at the bottom rung. We will begin at the bottom. You do not move up until the current rung feels much easier.

Rung	Challenge	Starting SUDS	Target SUDS after practice
Top (hardest)			
Middle			
Bottom (easiest)			

What I will NOT do during a challenge (response prevention)

For each challenge, the real work is facing it WITHOUT the coping reaction. List the reactions from Worksheet 1 that you agree to hold back on.

- I will not push the thought away or block it
- I will not ask for reassurance that I won't act
- I will not avoid the trigger or leave early
- I will not scratch myself or hold tight to 'stay in control'
- Instead, if distress is high, I will use my safe skill: _____

My agreement

I feel ready to start at rung: _____

Safe coping skill I will use instead of scratching/holding: _____

Signed (patient): _____ Clinician: _____ Date: _____